

PURELIVINGZONE · FREE GUIDE

The Ferment Guide

One jar, cabbage and salt — the ratio, the timing, and the one rule that keeps it safe.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. Sauerkraut is the simplest ferment there is: cabbage, salt, and time. No vinegar, no starter, no special kit. The salt and the cabbage's own wild bacteria do the work, turning it tangy, crisp, and alive. Get the salt right and keep it under the brine, and it almost cannot fail.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS

- **Lacto-fermentation** — salt holds off spoilage bacteria while the good ones turn the cabbage's sugars into tangy lactic acid. That acid is what preserves it.
 - **No vinegar** — the sourness is made, not added. This is different from quick pickling.
-

THE ONE RATIO TO REMEMBER

- **About 2% salt by weight** — roughly 1 tablespoon of fine salt per pound of cabbage (about 18–20 g per kg). Weigh it if you can; salt is what keeps it safe.
 - **Use plain salt** — non-iodized, no anti-caking additives (they cloud the brine).
-

THE METHOD

- **Shred** — slice the cabbage thin into a large bowl (keep one outer leaf aside).
 - **Salt and crush** — scatter the salt over it and massage and squeeze for several minutes until it wilts and releases a pool of its own brine.
 - **Pack** — press it firmly into a clean jar, pushing out air, until the brine rises above the cabbage.
 - **Submerge** — lay the reserved leaf on top and weigh it down (a small glass or a clean stone) so everything stays under the liquid. Cover loosely, or use an airlock, so gas can escape.
-

▲ THE RULE THAT KEEPS IT SAFE

- **Keep it under the brine** — everything below the liquid is protected. Anything poking above the brine can mold. Check daily and press it back down.
 - **Kahm vs mold** — a thin, flat white film (kahm yeast) is harmless; skim it off. Fuzzy, colored, or raised mold means discard the batch. Trust your nose: it should smell sour and clean, never rotten.
-

TIMING, THEN STORING

- **Cool room** — keep it around 60–70°F (16–21°C), out of direct sun, on a plate to catch overflow.
 - **Taste from day 5** — it is ready when it tastes pleasantly sour and stays crisp, usually 1–3 weeks. Longer means tangier.
 - **Move it cold** — once you like it, cap it and refrigerate. The cold nearly stops the ferment and it keeps for months.
 - **Variations** — a spoon of caraway seed, or shredded carrot and ginger, once you have the plain version down.
-

KEEP THIS IN MIND

Weigh the cabbage, then weigh 2% of that in salt. That single habit is the difference between a jar that works every time and one you have to guess at.

What they bottle and sell you, she kept alive in a crock by the door. One jar, and you never buy it again. — The Sage

SOURCES National Center for Home Food Preservation (nchfp.uga.edu) — fermenting sauerkraut · University of Minnesota Extension — fermenting vegetables safely · USDA Complete Guide to Home Canning — fermented foods

PURELIVINGZONE